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**PHRYGIAN FIBULAE
IN TRANSCAUCASIA:
THEIR DIFFUSION ROUTE**

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The Late Bronze-Early Iron Age transition in the Caucasus, specifically in Georgia, stands out for its particularly high level of skills in metallurgy. This is the time when the Bronze Age cultural traditions, already thousands of years old, reached a new stage of development; as an example of these advances can be offered the well-known Colchian culture which has been, for an appreciable length of time, the subject of intensive and varied research both in history (Koridze, 1965; Japaridze, 1969; Mikeladze, 1974) and in archaeology (Abramishvili, 1957; Lordkipanidze, 1972 & 1979) with special emphasis on the study of metallurgy (Abramishvili, 1961; Lordkipanidze, 1979). Many new technologies appeared in bronze metallurgy during the second half of the 2nd millennium with more improvements - including the development of iron technology - during the first centuries of the 1st millennium, the most important of which was the development of a variety of alloys each with specific qualities which made possible the production of improved agricultural implements, weapons and jewelry (Lordkipanidze, 1979: 37). It is important, furthermore, to underline the existence of major differences in Late Bronze-Early Iron Age metallurgy between the West and the Central Caucasus. The traditions in the former area derive mainly from local metal working techniques of the 2nd millennium B.C., while in the latter's case the links with past productions are hardly noticeable (Iessen, 1950: 80; Pantskhava, 1988: 8). Both areas, however, witnessed the creation of wonderful masterpieces in line drawing during the early 1st millennium B.C. (Khidasheli, 1972; Urushadze, 1984; Pantskhava, 1988).

This paper will concentrate on the Colchian cultural domain because of the presence there - and in Colchis mainly - of "sub-Mykenaian" fibulae whose decorative motifs and syntax became indissolubly linked with the local imagery. The thesis developed below, however, is that the term "sub-Mykenaian" is misleading and it will, therefore, be eschewed; the evidence from Transcaucasia makes it clear that our fibulae derive not from Greek prototypes directly, but rather from the Phrygian or Anatolian adaptation of early Iron Age Greek originals.

In Colchian works of art plot and character are tightly interweaved and shapes are represented more or less exclusively through the use of stereotypical elements whose combination obeys the rules of a strict decorative system (Pantskhava, 1988: 15). Although the fibulae themselves - the well-known "bow fibula" - are intrusive to Colchian culture, representing but a small portion of their very wide distribution area (Blinkenberg, 1926; Snodgrass, 1971: 347-348), the decorative schemes evidenced on them belong to that system: local decorative elements were simply adapted to a foreign medium.

Individual fibulae found in Transcaucasia show, for the most part, regularly curved bows of even thickness; the thickness of the bow, however, varies considerably from one example to the next. Although the majority of these bear no decoration whatsoever, several are ornamented with a wide range of motifs. Some are simple, constituted by the repetition of a single element over the entire length of the bow: deep parallel grooves which create the illusion that the bow is made up of a succession of beads, series of closely spaced transversal incisions, or parallel longitudinal incisions; to the same group belong fibulae whose bows are covered with a parallel incised herring-bone pattern. There is also a series of fibulae with more complex decoration, either combining different motifs in alternating zones, or showing the rhythmic grouping of simple designs separated by plain fields; most show series of parallel transverse incisions separated by either plain fields of more or less equal length, or cross-hatching, longitudinal incisions, beading etc. A third group, represented by much less frequent examples, shows rounded ridges or large beads at both extremities of the bow, these last are comparable to the decor of fibulae found in Armenia. Finally, some fibulae present a twisted bow.

The catch-plate (formed simply by hammering flat the extremity of the bow wire and bending it upwards so as to retain the pin), with its generally wide and flat surface, constitutes another area ideal for the placement of incised drawings. The decoration of the catch-plates is usually rather more complex than that seen on the bow, as is attested for example by finds from Tli, Mzetamze (pl. 1.1) or Koban (Uvarova, 1900; Krupnov, 1960: 80; Tekhov, 1980, 1981 & 1985; Nasidze & Licheli, 1996). On this surface often appear the figurative representations of animals: dogs mostly, but also sometimes fish or snakes; in addition, one can recognize a series of simple geometric designs, notably the "Maltese cross" (Pantskhava, 1988: 35).

All of the ornamental motifs mentioned above, both on bow and catch plate, can be found among the designs seen on the Colchian axe, and the complete repertoire does not extend beyond its artistic framework, either in the choice of individual elements or in their syntax. This is why, as was mentioned above, the fibulae are inseparable from Colchian culture - so much so that we are justified in calling them a Colchian reinterpretation of the Phrygian fibulae. It appears evident, both because of the suddenness of their presence and because of the considerable quantities of examples found, that from their very first occurrence in Transcaucasia such fibulae became commonly used and were, therefore, mass-produced by the Colchian bronzesmiths.

What is more, when attempting to interpret the drawings on the catch-plates, specifically the symbolic meanings of animal representation, we should draw from the body of local historically attested evidence. From this viewpoint, it must be noted in the first instance that the animals present on our fibulae occupied such an important place in the Caucasian imagination that their attributes survived even into Georgian Christian beliefs. Local ethnographic, linguistic and folkloric materials suggest that dog, snake and fish reflect similar images (Kikvidze, 1976: 7); namely the dog and the snake (alternately the fish) are related to one another and to water (Meshkhaninov, 1925). Concurrently, the fish is recognized as a creature associated with the deity of fertility; such a juxtaposition of a fish and a symbol of fertility is attested notably in Greek Archaic culture; it can be seen on a Late Geometric amphora of Boiotian origin where a fish accompanies the Potnia Theron (Harrison, 1908: 254).

The so-called "Maltese cross" which, along with the other geometric motifs, can be found on Colchian axes also symbolizes fertility. This notion is supported by the association of such motifs, on all kinds of Colchian objects, with the patron goddess of wild beasts, Dali, whose functional field includes such natural analogues as the great Ishtar, Artemis and Selene (Kikvidze, 1967: 221; Khidasheli, 1982: 111-134; Pantskhava, 1988: 52).

Whereas its decor can be firmly linked to local artistic traditions, the fibula itself as an object originates outside Colchian culture. What is of interest to us here is to examine the morphological similarities between our Colchian version of the Phrygian fibula and those - examples found in the Aigaian area and in Asia Minor in order to clarify the origins of the similarities. The fibulae discovered by the Swedish Archaeological Expedition in Cyprus and dated to the 10th century B.C. (Gjerstadt et al., 1935) are, from that point of view, of major relevance to our purpose. They are close in shape and type to the Colchian fibulae, but the manner in which the bows are decorated is somewhat different; for example Cypriot fibulae _ bows will show three circular longitudinal ridges, or an alternance of beaded and plain surface, decorative motifs unknown in Colchis; in parallel to such disparities, we notice similarities, for instance the presence in Cyprus of fibulae with an evenly bent bow decorated with two prominent rounded ridges at both ends (Gjerstadt et al., 1935: pl. CLII no. A. 516), a decoration type well-known on fibulae discovered in Armenia (Martirosian, 1964: 105).

Asia Minor, where bow fibulae are frequent also, provides a number of analogues for our Caucasian examples; this is true in particular of the fibulae found in Phrygia, and especially at Gordion. Phrygian fibulae closely resemble the types discovered in the Caucasus in that their bow is also evenly curved, but their catch-plates are quite distinctive. This is an important difference that prevents the actual identity of Phrygian and Colchian fibulae. Similarities between Caucasian and Phrygian fibulae can be found also in the decorative schemes; from that point of view useful comparisons can be made between Asia Minor fibulae such as those from the Gordion excavations exhibited in the Museum of Anatolian Civilizations at Ankara and those from most areas of the Caucasus: Colchis (Mikeladze, 1985: 47-49; Gogadze & Davlianidze, 1981: 56), Iberia, (Tzitlanadze, 1976: 79; Tekhov, 1980, 1981, 1985), Trialeti (Kuftin, 1941: 72) and the North Caucasus, whereas the fibulae from Armenia are exact copies of the former.

Phrygian fibulae are generally attributed an East Greek origin, an idea supported by the fact that the only known Phrygian type fibula mould has been found at Izmir; the representation of fibulae on early coins, furthermore, has even been related to their possible use as a form of currency (Boardman, 1973: 85). If we add to that the discovery of traces of sub-Mykenian culture on the islands of Lesbos, Samos and Khios, the case for the Aigaian origin of the Phrygian fibulae finds itself strengthened.

Consequently, if we take into account the close morphological similarities of Phrygian and Transcaucasian fibulae, it will appear evident that the fibulae types produced throughout the Caucasus area should have been introduced through the movement of goods from Asia Minor, namely Phrygia (the major Anatolian power down to the end of the 8th century), rather than directly from Greek prototypes transported via the Black Sea. Of course such a conclusion is based on circumstantial evidence, for no early Phrygian (or Greek) fibula has yet been unearthed in the territory of Georgia. Finds other than fibulae strengthen our case, however, the most remarkable of which is the recent discovery in Borjomi Ravine - located in the mountainous ridge at the extreme South of Iberia and thus close to Colchis - of a bronze statuette representing a helmeted man and similar to Phrygian sculpture (Gambashidze & Gambashidze, 1987: 40-41, no. 4). It is certainly not a coincidence that the Mzetamze necropolis which produced one of the highest concentrations of bronze bow fibulae in almost all Transcaucasia is located also in the vicinity of Borjomi. The Necropolis of Mzetamzi is an important monument in many ways, because many things confirming the relationship with the outside world have been found here (for example, a mug of local production decorated with a simple meander from the 7th century BC. and Neo-Babylonian dagger of 7th c BC. pl. 2)

Finally, new discoveries suggest that the dates used so far for the fibulae are in need of some correcting, work which is being done currently by U. Pantzkhava; in this light. therefore, we believe that the so-called sub-Mykenian (but more appropriately Phrygian) fibulae first appeared in the Caucasus as early as the 7th century B.C.

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Pl. 1.



